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‘*Prayaschitta*’

Given Mahatma Gandhi’s joint culpability with Lord Irwin in the death of Bhagat Singh, what India needs today more than a mere apology is a psychic process of decolonization, similar to what the Germans have undergone in the ‘de-nazification’ of their past. It is for this reason that an apology on its own would serve no purpose unless also accompanied by such a process. This is manifest from how in 2019 the German president asked the Poles to forgive Germany for the Second World War at an event in Warsaw to mark the eightieth anniversary of the Nazi attack on Poland, a country which suffered the most war-related deaths per capita of any country. Some 17% of the nation’s population was wiped out when six million Poles, half of whom were Jews, were killed. In the face of the Polish prime minister’s clamour for an enhanced apology, the German president was disarmingly apologetic: ‘I bow before the victims of the attack. I bow before the Polish victims of German tyranny. And I ask your forgiveness,’ he pleaded. He then continued, with the words, ‘We want to, and we will, remember. And we will bear the responsibility that our history imposes on us.’[1]

There is a lesson to be learnt here. Germany is able to do this because it has committed itself to making amends for the wrongs and injuries that it committed during the Second World War. It even has a specific term for it. The word, ‘*Vergangenheitsbewältigung*’ implies a ‘struggle to overcome the [negatives of the] past’ or ‘working through the past’. It is said that there isn’t a native equivalent for this word in any other language. Yet, beginning in the 1960s, it has engaged in a decades-long exercise in examining, analysing and ultimately learning to live with an evil chapter in Germany’s